

Bash Shortcuts

These are Readline (Emacs-mode) key bindings — they work the same in Bash, Zsh, and most REPLs, on Linux and macOS. Learning even the top row (`Ctrl-A` , `Ctrl-R` , `Ctrl-W`) makes the shell dramatically faster.

Move the Cursor

Keys	Moves to
<code>Ctrl-A</code>	start of the line
<code>Ctrl-E</code>	end of the line
<code>Alt-B</code>	back one word
<code>Alt-F</code>	forward one word
<code>Ctrl-XX</code>	toggle between start and current position

Edit the Line

Keys	Does
<code>Ctrl-W</code>	delete the word before the cursor
<code>Ctrl-U</code>	delete from cursor to start of line
<code>Ctrl-K</code>	delete from cursor to end of line
<code>Ctrl-Y</code>	paste (yank) what you just deleted
<code>Alt-D</code>	delete the word after the cursor
<code>Ctrl-T</code>	transpose (swap) the last two characters
<code>Alt-U</code> / <code>Alt-L</code>	uppercase / lowercase the next word
<code>Ctrl-_</code>	undo the last edit

Cut and paste, shell-style. `Ctrl-U` , `Ctrl-K` , and `Ctrl-W` don't just delete — they cut into a buffer. `Ctrl-Y` pastes it back, so you can move text around the line.

History

Keys / token	Does
<code>Ctrl-R</code>	reverse-search history (type to filter)
<code>Ctrl-G</code>	cancel the history search
<code>Ctrl-P / Ctrl-N</code>	previous / next command
<code>Alt-.</code>	insert the last argument of the previous command
<code>!!</code>	the entire previous command
<code>!\$</code>	the last argument of the previous command
<code>!abc</code>	the most recent command starting with abc

The classic sudo rescue

```
apt update          # oops, permission denied
sudo !!             # re-runs: sudo apt update
```

Control the Shell

Keys	Does
<code>Ctrl-C</code>	interrupt the running command
<code>Ctrl-D</code>	end of input / log out of the shell
<code>Ctrl-Z</code>	suspend to the background (<code>fg</code> to resume)
<code>Ctrl-L</code>	clear the screen (same as <code>clear</code>)
<code>Ctrl-S / Ctrl-Q</code>	pause / resume terminal output